

Why is AI bad for the environment?

Posted by u/Wild-Lie6451 • 0 points • 5 comments

I've seen this so many times that I've taken it to be true, but while I was trying to convince someone of this, I realized that the argument that AI uses up a ridiculous amount of water doesn't make sense to me because the water will become vapor and return in the form of rain. There are also other arguments that I am less familiar with that I'm trying to understand. Can someone explain why AI is harmful to the environment?

Comments

u/shootYrTv • 0 points • 2025-06-15 00:32 UTC

The water becomes vapor and returns as rain... to the ocean. In places with little rainfall (like California, where the vast majority of these server centers are) water is, for most intents and purposes, a limited resource that needs to be pumped in from elsewhere. AI server centers using gallons of water per AI result is very environmentally unsustainable.

The amount of electricity needed is also a massive problem, when the vast majority of electrical power is generated by fossil fuels in the US. Again, pounds of coal are burned for a single ChatGPT response.

u/Mango-is-Mango • 2 points • 2025-06-15 00:34 UTC

> Again, pounds of coal are burned for a single ChatGPT response.

That's not at all accurate

u/Monte_Cristos_Count • 1 points • 2025-06-15 00:30 UTC

Asking chatgpt to generate an image uses the same amount of electricity as it would take to charge an iPhone three times.

Chatgpt alone gets millions of prompts daily (not to mention the other AI services).

There's been serious talk of AI companies creating their own renewable energy grids that will solely power their computers.

u/Nondescript_585_Guy • 3 points • 2025-06-15 00:28 UTC

The server farms also use a ton of electricity, and electricity isn't always generated using the cleanest methods.

u/grogi81 • 1 points • 2025-06-15 07:06 UTC

